

HOLD THE LINE Opposition leaders protest outside Parliament over the NEET paper leak issue, July 23

57 PER CENT of respondents now feel that Congress is the real Opposition party

still sees Congress as clearly or to some extent the weak link in the alliance. But it's better than January's 62.3 per cent, while the share rejecting the description has risen from 29.3 to 32.9 per cent. The Congress is recovering ground, but too many voters seem to hold two thoughts at once: it is the only Opposition party with a truly national footprint, yet it may still be too weak to carry the alliance.

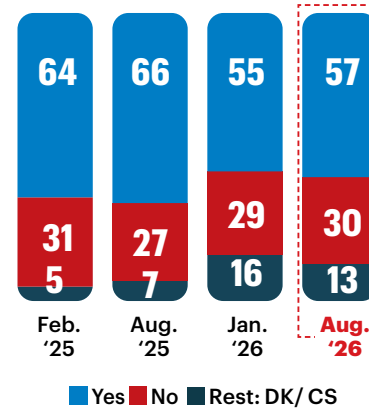
Then there is Gen Z, the constituency Rahul has been chasing through Chhatron Ki Goonj, 'Ask Me Anything' sessions and other direct outreach. The findings suggest young voters view him not very differently from everyone else. Among the Gen Z, 49.7 per cent rate his LS performance 'outstanding' or 'good', against 48.2 per cent overall. The Congress's positive performance rating is 42.3 per cent, against 40.6 per cent overall. These are useful points, but hardly evidence of a Rahul youth wave.

The choice of prime minister tells a similar story. Rahul is at 27.4 per cent, virtually identical to his 27.1 per cent overall. The same nuance appears on Opposition leadership. Rahul gets 27 per cent among Gen Z, against 29 per cent overall. Vijay rises to 12.7 per cent from 12.2, while Akhilesh goes to 7.4 from 6.9. Yet when the question is narrowed to who should lead the Congress, Rahul does better, with Gen Z at 43.8 per cent against 40.5 per cent overall.

Gen Z is also a little less harsh on Congress; 54.7 per cent call it a weak link in INDIA, against 58 per cent overall. But then, only 53.7 per cent say Congress is the real Opposition party, below the overall 56.6 per cent, with more young respondents unsure.

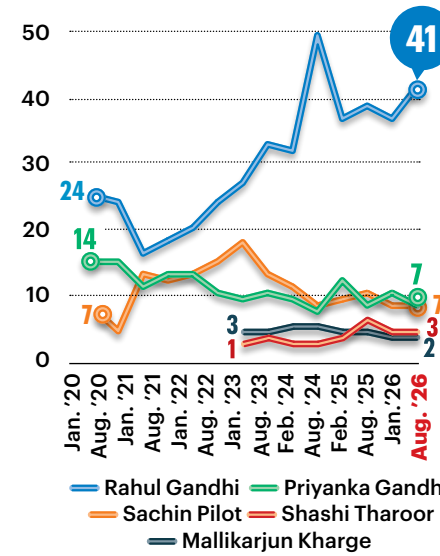
So the larger story is this: an anti-incumbency opening does not automatically translate into support for the Opposition. Rahul has improved his performance ratings but has not yet captured the political space created by Modi's drop in popularity. Established Opposition leaders have faded, while a newcomer such as Vijay is finding room. A dominant ownership position of the Opposition space is still up for grabs. ■

Q. Do you see Congress as the real Opposition party?



The national party is still the favoured alternative

Q. Which Congress leader is best suited to lead the party?



Rahul consolidates gains, now has few peers in the party